

HLP 4 & 5 Learning Module

Leading for Culturally Responsive Assessments in Special Education

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REMINDER

Complete the **Pre-Assessment** on Google Forms before starting this video.



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PART 1

CULTURALLY RESPONSIVE ASSESSMENT:

Descriptions and How-Tos



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THE PROBLEM: MARGINALIZATION

There exists a “prevalence of discipline referrals, special education referrals, suspensions, and expulsions for Black students based on behaviors that are considered normal in many Black families and communities.”

—Evans & Taylor, 2025, p. 369

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MARGINALIZATION

“Marginalization through special education is an especially acute concern for students of color and students with disabilities because special education has been used as a tool to maintain the segregation of these populations.”

—Newell, 2020, p.3

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NATIONAL DISPROPORTIONALITY DATA

Persistent Overrepresentation in Intellectual Disability Identification

- During the 2023–2024 school year, Black and African American students represented **16.96%** of students served under IDEA Part B but accounted for **25.74%** of students identified with an *intellectual disability*.
- Research consistently documents this pattern of overrepresentation.
- Despite increased awareness and policy efforts, disproportionate identification rates continue in special education evaluations.

Implication: Educators must use culturally responsive, data-based, and nondiscriminatory assessment practices to ensure equitable identification decisions.

Source: U.S. Department of Education (2025); Alqarni (2016); Elder et al. (2021); Gibson (2022)



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How Assessment HLPs 4 & 5 Benefit Students

“A justice-oriented, antiracist assessment approach . . . [requires] an explicit confrontation of racism in our assessment practices and works to disrupt these systems of oppression through assessment practices specifically designed to sustain, not eradicate, students’ cultures, languages, and ways of knowing/being.”

—Randall et al., 2022, p. 172

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Every educational leader, instructor, and staff member has a role in developing culturally responsive practices, including the personal task of reflecting about race. Implicit bias is not unique to dominant racial groups; individuals of all racial backgrounds harbor unconscious associations regarding race.

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Utilizing High-Leverage Practices

“Developed by the Council for Exceptional Children and the CEEDAR Center, high-leverage practices are 22 essential special education techniques that all teachers of students with disabilities should master.”

—The IRIS Center, 2026

These techniques include culturally responsive assessment procedures.

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HLP 4 & HLP 5 GUIDANCE

Special Education Directors can find essential tools for guiding teachers about culturally responsive assessment practices in HLP 4 and HLP 5. These processes appear in *High-leverage Practices for Students with Disabilities* (2nd ed.), edited by Aceves & Kennedy (2024).



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HLP 4: USE MULTIPLE DATA SOURCES

Considering Culture and Language in Assessment

- A comprehensive student profile must examine how **culture, language, and life experiences** may influence student performance.
- Assessments may contain **cultural, linguistic, and socioeconomic biases** that can affect results.
- Relying on a single assessment or data source can lead to **incomplete or inaccurate conclusions** about a student's strengths and needs.
- Culturally responsive assessment practices draw on **multiple sources of data** to support equitable decision-making.

Source: Aceves & Kennedy (2024).



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When educators use multiple sources of data, including informal assessments that validate and consider students' linguistic and cultural identities, it provides a stronger and more robust student profile that will assist in making instructional decisions (Riddle, 2017).

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FOUR STEPS FOR USING MULTIPLE SOURCES



Mix it Up

Use formal and informal assessments to gather information about students' academic strengths and weaknesses.



Let Them Speak

Seek input from students about their preferences, strengths, needs, and long-term goals.



Bring it Home

Seek input from family members for insights into interests, motivations, health, and cultural experiences.



Add it Up

Utilize information gathered from various sources to develop a comprehensive learner profile and inform IEP decisions.

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HLP 4: TIPS FOR DIRECTORS TO SUPPORT TEACHERS

Ensure Access: Ensure each educator knows about, and has access to, appropriate and minimally biased assessments for the student's age and level of cognitive and functional skills.

Provide Instruction: Provide instruction about how to interpret data sources of various types and how they collectively produce a comprehensive portrait of students' strengths, needs, and present levels.

Deliver Feedback: Deliver feedback to the educator on their skill in administering and interpreting data from various sources.



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HLP 5: Interpret and Communicate Assessment Information with Stakeholders to Collaboratively Design and Implement Educational Programs

Assessment data can be overwhelming for educators, so it is not surprising families and students may feel anxious about the communication of data results.

Keep Everyone on Track

The cultural considerations focus on **INCLUDING** and **INCORPORATING** all stakeholders in the evaluation journey.



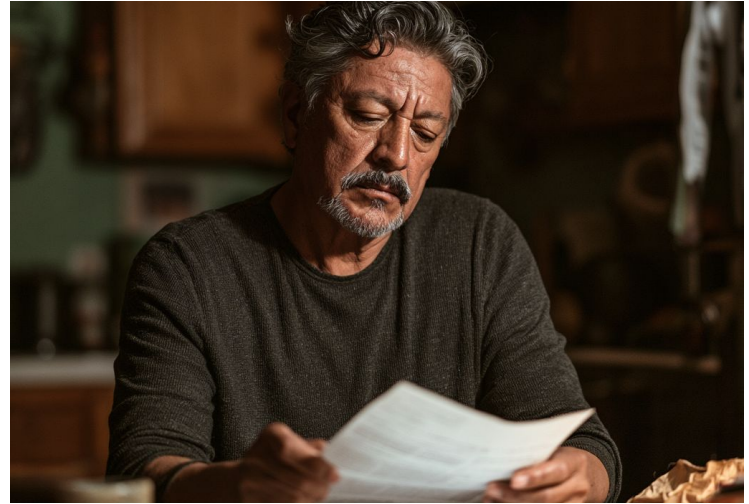
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HLP 5: FAMILY INVOLVEMENT & COLLABORATION

Family involvement, by recognizing and valuing family input, is an important cultural and linguistic consideration. Educators can assist in alleviating these feelings by taking an active role in including families.

Providing assessment results in easily understandable, jargon-free language prior to a meeting can allow families to digest information and form questions.



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HLP 5: FAMILY INVOLVEMENT & COLLABORATION

Involving Families in Assessment Conversations

In meetings, educators must dedicate enough time to ensure every partner, including families, understands the assessment results, and can ask questions or provide perspectives that may include factors related to culture and language.



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HLP 5: COMMUNICATION

Related to the guidance in HLP 5, Voulgarides (2018) provides recommendations about addressing disproportionality.

These methods can be applied by education leaders when advising teachers about creating culturally responsive assessments.



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HLP 5: COMMUNICATION

- Ensure that all school-based teams [and] special education offices . . . have a comprehensive understanding of disproportionality, and educational inequity more broadly, within their schools.
- Ensure that staff are aware, and know how to respond accordingly, that culture is dynamic, complex, constantly evolving, and embedded in every aspect of the teaching and learning process.



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HLP 5: COMMUNICATION

- Ensure that educators develop the capacity to have meaningful conversations with one another about how race, culture, diversity, equity, inclusion, sexuality, country of origin, and so forth relate to their educational practice and student outcomes.
- Ensure that educators acknowledge that professional development is a lifelong learning process.



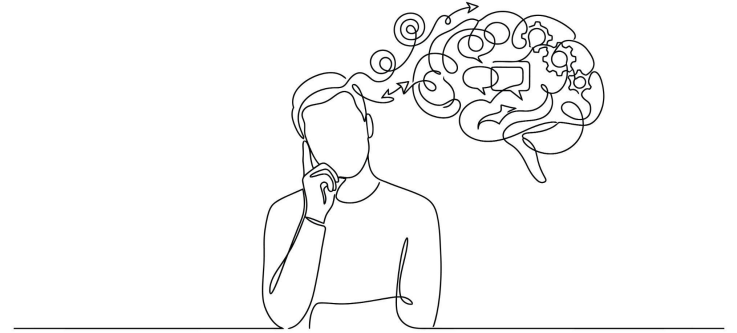
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PART 2: THE INNER WORK OF TACKLING MARGINALIZATION AND DISPROPORTIONALITY

Self-Reflection

Mindful reflection is a step-by-step method for checking unconscious biases, popularized for educators in *Mindful Reflection as a Process for Developing Culturally Responsive Practices* (Dray and Wisneski, 2011).



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REFLECT, MODEL, REPEAT

Like all educators, educational leaders must become increasingly proficient at uncovering biases in evaluation reports by consistently examining their own implicit biases (Aston & Brown, 2021; Dray & Wisneski, 2011).

**“We do not have to remain stuck in notions of difference as we engage in the work to repair the harms that difference makes”
(Magee, 2019, p. 244).**

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REFLECT, MODEL, REPEAT

Cultural competence includes knowledge of

- (a) one's culture and worldview;
- (b) **one's biases and prejudice;**
- (c) students' cultures and worldviews; and
- (d) the ability to understand the world through the lens of cultural diversity and use this knowledge to increase the quality of services to produce better outcomes

(Aston & Brown, 2021; Dray & Wisneski, 2011).



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REFLECT, MODEL, REPEAT

- Engage in reflection to increase the validity and trustworthiness of special education assessment.
- Directors of Special Education, and any educational leader, can use the protocol to continue developing their culturally responsive behaviors and to guide special educator teachers in the practice.



CULTURAL RESPONSIVENESS: “Having an awareness of the cultural racial issues faced by others and the ability to reflect and respond according to the needs of individuals.”

— Owiny & Cornelius, 2024, p. 104

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Step 1: Explain the attributions that you have about the student

Teacher: Recall an incident in which you perceived a student of color being disrespectful, defiant, or refusing to comply with your instruction, and documented it.

Question 1: Did you jump to conclusions about a student's behavior and why the student behaved that way?

Question 2: Describe what you and the student did, and in what order—Did you already pass judgement on the behavior as good or bad?

Question 3: What leads you to believe the behavior was wrong [instead of unexpected, uninvited, etc.]?

SPED Director

Q1: Does the teacher's description of this behavior in the assessment need more clarification?

Q2: Do you suspect an inaccuracy? Why?

[Note: Unless directly quoted, teacher's questions are adapted from Dray & Wisneski (2011) and SPED Director suggestions written by A. Felix]

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Step 2: Write out and reflect on your feelings and thoughts when working with the student

Teacher

Question 1: Am I assigning certain attributes to this student?

Question 2: How does this student make me feel?

Question 3: What are my worries or fears?

Question 4: What are my assumptions—why do I find the student's behavior problematic?

SPED Director

Q1: What are my assumptions about this teacher?

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Step 3: Consider alternative explanations by reviewing your documentation and reflections

Teacher

Question 1: What are my expectations for the situation?

Question 2: In what way is the student not conforming with my expectations?

Question 3: How is this student's behavior interfering with learning?

SPED Director

Q1: Do the teacher's expectations sound valid for all students?

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Step 4: Check your assumptions

Teacher

Question 1: Does the student's family notice the same behavior at home?

Question 2: Am I aware of how family members interact with the student at home? If I am, describe this type of interaction.

Question 3: Have there been any changes or upsets in the home?

SPED Director

Q1: Do the teacher's descriptions of family interactions with the student align with other assessment documents?

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Step 5: Make a plan

Teacher

Question 1:

How can I change or respond differently?

Question 2: What resources do I need to change my responses/actions and/or the classroom environment?

SPED Director

Q1: Am I offering adequate professional development for addressing implicit biases?

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Step 6: Continuously revisit this process to reassess your attributions and your progress with the student

Teacher

Question 1: Am I strengthening my relationship with this student?

Question 2: Do I understand this student better?

Question 3: Am I changing my behavior with all students in the classroom?

SPED Director

Q1: Do I make assumptions about this teacher based on race?

Q2: Am I providing positive feedback to this teacher about their progress with this student?

Q3: Are my feedback processes sufficient?

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THE END GOAL

“Create a **culturally and linguistically responsive** and supportive learning community that recognizes and celebrates differences.”

(Dray & Wisneski, 2011, p. 34)

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RESOURCES

Visit [THE CEEDAR CENTER](#)

CEEDAR stands for “Collaboration for Effective Educator Development, Accountability, and Reform.”

READ

Dray, B. J., & Wisneski, D. B. (2011). Mindful reflection as a process for developing culturally responsive practices. *TEACHING Exceptional Children*, 44(1), 28–36.

<https://doi.org/10.1177/004005991104400104>

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